

Bharat BUYING

Armed with innovative pricing and smart marketing strategies, marketers are venturing deep into the hinterland looking for more buyers. And rural India is happy to be wooed.

By Malini Bhupta
with Nandini Vaish

Shanti Tirunavukarasu and her husband Srinivas, a paddy farmer in Thanjavur, look forward to their wedding anniversary more than any other festival. That's the day they are rewarded for being loyal customers of Gold

Plus, Titan's jewellery retail venture in rural India. Every year, the company sends them complimentary tickets to the latest Tamil flick in town along with a box of prasadam from Tirupati.

Till recently, the family would head to Chennai after every harvest with a long shopping list, but ever since Gold Plus has opened its store in this hamlet, the Tirunavukarasus no longer rush

to big cities to buy jewellery. Says Shanti: "The biggest draw for us is that it's a Tata venture so we trust it and also the store has a carat-meter that helps me measure the purity of my gold. Even if the jewellery is expensive, I still prefer to come here." Movie tickets and a box of prasadam is not such a big price to pay for customer loyalty.

In another far-flung village

Dabur

RURAL INITIATIVE: Dabur's rural sales strategy covers villages with population of under 3,000 across seven states. The company has also moved beyond the traditional media options and directly engages with consumers with ideas like a rural beauty and talent contest with Dabur Amla Hair Oil.

RURAL SALES: Rs. **1,155** crore*

ALL INDIA SALES: Rs. **2,310** crore

*Approximately

